

TEN CENT POCKET SERIES NO. 351

Edited by E. Haldeman-Julius

Memories of Lincoln

Walt Whitman

HALDEMAN-JULIUS COMPANY
GIRARD, KANSAS

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK MEMORIES OF
LINCOLN ***

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sublime,

and drums.

hour,

standing like a tower,

He knew to bide his time,
And can his fame abide,
Still patient in his simple faith

Till the wise years decide.
Great captains, with their guns

Disturb our judgment for the

But at last silence comes;
These all are gone, and,

Our children shall behold his

fame.

foreseeing man,

praise, not blame,

first American.

The kindly-earnest, brave,

Sagacious, patient, dreading

New birth of our new soil, the

JAMES RUSSELL LOWELL

FOREWORD

Whitman did not subject Lincoln to the literary but to the human motive. Lincoln does not become a literary figure by his touch. Does not become a man in a book. After Whitman is done with him Lincoln still remains Lincoln. No way reduced. No way aggrandized. Only better understood. His background does not become a book. His background remains what it was. Remains life. Generic life. As life is where life finds life at the root. I may let Whitman put in a word for himself. Whitman said to me of Lincoln:

"Lincoln is particularly my man—particularly belongs to me; yes, and by the same token I am Lincoln's man: I guess I particularly belong to him: we are afloat in the same stream—we are rooted in the same ground."

To know the Lincoln of Whitman you want to know the Whitman of Whitman. Whitman was literary. But he was not first of all literary. Or last of all literary. First of all he was human. He was not the leaves of a book. He was the bone and flesh of a man. Yes, he was that something or other not bone or flesh which is also of a man—which finally is the man. Simply literary analysis can make little out of Whitman. He does not yield to the scalpel. He is not to be resurrected from an inkpot. His voice falls in with the prophet voices. He was not unlettered. He knew the alphabet. But he kept all alphabetical, arrogance well in hand. The letter was kept in hand. The spirit was left free. You cannot buy a ticket for Athens or Weimar or Paris or London or Boston and reach Whitman. He is never reached in that circle. The literary centers do not lead to him. You have got to travel to him by another route. You go East and find the Buddhistic canticles. You consult

the Zoroastrian avatars. And you take the word of Jesus for a great deal. And you may hit Socrates on the way. And you keep on with your journey, touching here and there in European history certain men, certain influences. Going into port now and then. Never going where men compete for literary judgment. Never where men set out to acquit themselves immortally as artists. Keeping forever close to the careless rhythms of original causes. So you go on. And go on. And by and by you arrive at Whitman. Not by way of the university. Not by way of Shakespeare. Not by way of the literary experts and adepts. But by human ways. To try to find Whitman by way of Shakespeare or Molière would be hopeless. I do not disparage the other routes to other men. I am only describing this route to Whitman. This route, which is the only route. Whitman chants and prays and soars. He is not pretty. He is only beautiful. He is not beautiful with the beauty of beauty. He is beautiful with the beauty of truth. The pen can easily miss Whitman. But the heart reaches him direct. Whitman is therefore the best route to Lincoln. The same process which provides Whitman for you provided Lincoln for. Whitman. Whitman said to me again about Lincoln:

"There was no reason why Lincoln should not have been a prophet rather than a politician; he was in fact a divine prophet-politician; in him for almost the first time prophecy had something to say in politics. I shouldn't wonder but that in another age of the world Lincoln would have been a chosen man to lead in some rebellion against ecclesiastical institutions and religious form and ceremony."

HORACE TRAUBEL

The main effect of this poem is of strong solemn, and varied music; and it involves in its construction a principle after which perhaps the great composers most work—namely, spiritual auricular analogy. At first it would seem to defy analysis, so rapt is it, and so indirect. No reference whatever is made to the mere fact of Lincoln's death; the poet does not even dwell upon its unprovoked atrocity, and only occasionally is the tone that of lamentation; but, with the intuitions of the grand art, which is the most complex when it seems most simple, he seizes upon three beautiful facts of nature, which he weaves into a wreath for the dead President's tomb. The central thought is of death, but around this he curiously twines, first, the

early-blooming lilacs which the poet may have plucked the day the dark shadow came; next the song of the hermit thrush, the most sweet and solemn of all our songsters, heard at twilight in the dusky cedars; and with these the evening star, which, as many may remember, night after night in the early part of that eventful spring, hung low in the west with unusual and tender brightness. These are the premises whence he starts his solemn chant.

The attitude, therefore, is not that of being bowed down and weeping hopeless tears, but of singing a commemorative hymn, in which the voices of nature join, and fits that exalted condition of the soul which serious events and the presence of death induce.

JOHN BURROUGHS

I. WHEN LILACS LAST IN THE DOORYARD BLOOM'D

1

in the	When lilacs last in the dooryard bloom'd, And the great star early droop'd
with	western sky in the night, I mourn'd, and yet shall mourn
to	ever-returning spring. Ever-returning spring, trinity sure
drooping	me you bring, Lilac blooming perennial and star in the west, And thought of him I love.

2

tearful

black

powerless—

will not

farmhouse

with

green,

rising

strong

from

and

green,

O powerful western fallen star!
O shades of night—O moody,

night!
O great star disappear'd—O the

murk that hides the star!
O cruel hands that hold me

O helpless soul of me!
O harsh surrounding cloud that
free my soul.

3

In the dooryard fronting an old

near the white-wash'd
palings,
Stands the lilac-bush tall-growing

heart-shaped leaves of rich
With many a pointed blossom
delicate, with the perfume

I love,
With every leaf a miracle—and

this bush in the dooryard,
With delicate-color'd blossoms

heart-shaped leaves of rich
A sprig with its flower I break.

4

recesses,
warbling a

In the swamp in secluded
A shy and hidden bird is
song.

avoiding

Solitary the thrush,
The hermit withdrawn to himself,
the settlements,
Sings by himself a song.

well

Song of the bleeding throat,
Death's outlet song of life, (for

thou

dear brother I know,
If thou wast not granted to sing
would'st surely die.)

5

land,

Over the breast of the spring, the

woods,

amid cities,
Amid lanes and through old

peep'd

where lately the violets

the

from the ground, spotting

side of

gray debris,
Amid the grass in the fields each
the lanes, passing the

endless

every

white

shall rest

grass,
Passing the yellow-spear'd wheat,

grain from its shroud in the
dark-brown fields uprisen,
Passing the apple-tree blows of

and pink in the orchards,
Carrying a corpse to where it

in the grave,
Night and day journeys a coffin.

6

and

great

flags

black,

themselves

standing,

winding and

with the

unbared

Coffin that passes through lanes

streets,
Through day and night with the

cloud darkening the land,
With the pomp of the inloop'd

with the cities draped in
With the show of the States

as of crape-veil'd women
With processions long and

the flambeaus of the night,
With the countless torches lit,

silent sea of faces and the

arriving
faces,
with the
strong

the
coffin,
shuddering
you

perpetual

heads,
With the waiting depot, the
coffin, and the sombre
With dirges through the night,
thousand voices rising
and solemn,
With all the mournful voices of
dirges pour'd around the
The dim-lit churches and the
organs—where amid these
journey,
With the tolling, tolling bell's
clang,
Here, coffin that slowly passes,
I give you my sprig of lilac.

7

coffins

would

sane

(Nor for you, for one alone,
Blossoms and branches green to
all I bring,
For fresh as the morning, thus
I chant a song for you O
and sacred death.
All over bouquets of roses,

roses and

sprigs

pouring for

O

meant

transparent

tell as

night,

down

other

solemn

know

O death, I cover you over with

early lilies,

But mostly and now the lilac that

blooms the first,

Copious I break, I break the

from the bushes,

With loaded arms I come,

you,

For you and the coffins all of you

death.)

8

O western orb sailing the heaven,

Now I know what you must have

as a month since I walk'd,

As I walk'd in silence the

shadowy night,

As I saw you had something to

you bent to me night after

As you droop'd from the sky low

as if to my side, (while the

stars all look'd on,)

As we wander'd together the

night, (for something I

sleep,)

on the

you

the

transparent

and was

black of

dissatisfied

and was

not what kept me from

As the night advanced, and I saw

rim of the west how full

were of woe,

As I stood on the rising ground in

breeze in the cool

night,

As I watch'd where you pass'd

lost in the netherward

the night,

As my soul in its trouble

sank, as where you sad orb.

Concluded, dropt in the night,

gone.

9

hear your

understand

lustrous

Sing on there in the swamp,

O singer bashful and tender, I

notes, I hear your call,

I hear, I come presently, I

you,

But a moment I linger, for the

star has detain'd me,

The star my departing comrade

holds

and detains me.

10

the

O how shall I warble myself for

for the

dead one there I loved?

gone?

And how shall I deck my song

for the

large sweet soul that has

And what shall my perfume be

grave of him I love?

west,

Sea-winds blown from east and

blown

Blown from the Eastern sea and

there

from the Western sea, till

on the prairies meeting,

breath of

These and with these and the

my chant,

love.

I'll perfume the grave of him I

11

chamber

O what shall I hang on the

walls?

that I

And what shall the pictures be

I

farms

sundown,

and

the

sun,

under

leaves

the

wind-dapple

with

sky, and

dwellings so

chimneys,

hang on the walls,
To adorn the burial-house of him

love?

Pictures of growing spring and

and homes,
With the Fourth-month eve at

and the gray smoke lucid

bright,
With floods of the yellow gold of

gorgeous, indolent, sinking

burning, expanding the air,
With the fresh sweet herbage

foot, and the pale green

of the trees prolific,
In the distance the flowing glaze,

breast of the river, with a

here and there,
With ranging hills on the banks,

many a line against the

shadows,
And the city at hand with

dense, and stacks of

workshops,
homeward

And all the scenes of life and the
and the workmen
returning.

12

and
tides,

South
Ohio's
Missouri,
prairies
corn.

Lo, body and soul—this land,
My own Manhattan with spires,

the sparkling and hurrying
and the ships,
The varied and ample land, the
and the North in the light,
shores and flashing
And ever the far-spreading
cover'd with grass and

calm and

just-felt

light.
all, the

Lo, the most excellent sun so
haughty,
The violet and purple morn with
breezes,
The gentle soft-born measureless
The miracle spreading bathing
fulfill'd noon,
The coming eve delicious, the

welcome

enveloping

night and the stars,
Over my cities shining all,
man and land.

13

bird,

recesses,

bushes,

the

your

uttermost

Song on, sing on you gray-brown
Sing from the swamps, the
pour your chant from the
Limitless out of the dusk, out of
cedars and pines.

Sing on dearest brother, warble
reedy song,
Loud human song, with voice of
woe.

wondrous

holds me,

holds

O liquid and free and tender!
O wild and loose to my soul—O
singer!
You only I hear—yet the star
(but will soon depart,)
Yet the lilac with mastering odor
me.

14

look'd

light

and the

crops,

of my

forests,

(after

afternoon

women,

I saw

with

busy

how

its

Now while I sat in the day and

forth,

In the close of the day with its

and the fields of spring,

farmers preparing their

In the large unconscious scenery

land with its lakes and

In the heavenly aerial beauty,

the perturb'd winds and the
storms,)

Under the arching heavens of the

swift passing, and the
voices of children and

The many-moving sea-tides, and

the ships how they sail'd,
And the summer approaching

richness, and the fields all

with labor,
And the infinite separate houses,

they all went on, each with

meals and minutia of daily
usages,

And the streets how their

throbbings

pent—lo,

them

rest,

long

and the

death as

walking

companions,

receiving night

the

dimness,

and

throbb'd, and the cities

then and there,

Falling upon them all and among

all, enveloping me with the

Appear'd the cloud, appear'd the

black trail,

And I knew death, its thought,

sacred knowledge of death.

Then with the knowledge of

walking one side of me,

And the thought of death close-

the other side of me,

And I in the middle as with

and as holding the hands of
companions,

I fled forth to the hiding

that talks not,

Down to the shores of the water,

path by the swamp in the

To the solemn shadowy cedars

ghostly pines so still.

And the singer so shy to the rest

receiv'd

and a

me,

comrades

the

serenely arriving,

each,

universe,

and

receiv'd me,
The gray-brown bird I know

us comrades three,
And he sang the carol of death,

verse for him I love.

From deep secluded recesses,
From the fragrant cedars and the
ghostly pines so still,
Came the carol of the bird.

And the charm of the carol rapt

As I held as if by their hands my

in the night,
And the voice of my spirit tallied

song of the bird.

*Come lovely and soothing death,
Undulate round the world,*

*arriving,
In the day, in the night, to all, to*

Sooner or later delicate death.

Prais'd be the fathomless

For life and joy, and for objects

*knowledge curious,
And for love, sweet
praise! praise!*

with

chant of

thee

thou

unfalteringly.

taken

dead,

of thee,

death.

saluting thee,

for

landscape

are fitting,

*For the sure-enwinding arms of
cool-enfolding death.
Dark mother always gliding near*

*soft feet,
Have none chanted for thee a*

*fullest welcome?
Then I chant it for thee, I glorify*

*above all,
I bring thee a song that when*

must indeed come, come

*Approach strong deliveress,
When it is so, when thou hast*

them I joyously sing the

Lost in the loving floating ocean

Laved in the flood of thy bliss O

*From me to thee glad serenades,
Dances for thee I propose*

adornments and feastings

*thee,
And the sights of the open*

and the high-spread sky

And life and the fields, and the

huge

a star,

whispering

vast and

close

song,

leaves, over

prairies

and the

to

and thoughtful night.

The night in silence under many

The ocean shore and the husky

*wave whose voice I know,
And the soul turning to thee O*

*well-veil'd death,
And the body gratefully nestling*

*to thee.
Over the tree-tops I float thee a*

Over the rising and sinking

the myriad fields and the

*wide,
Over the dense-pack'd cities all*

*teeming wharves and ways,
I float this carol with joy, with joy*

thee O death.

15

gray-brown

spreading

*To the tally of my soul,
Loud and strong kept up the*

*bird,
With pure deliberate notes*

filling the night.

the Loud in the pines and cedars dim,
Clear in the freshness moist and
the swamp-perfume,
And I with my comrades there in
night.
While my sight that was bound in
my eyes unclosed,
As to long panoramas of visions.
And I saw askant the armies,
I saw as in noiseless dreams
hundreds of battle-flags,
Borne through the smoke of the
battles and pierc'd with missiles I
saw them,
And carried hither and yon
through the smoke, and torn and
bloody, And at last but a few shreds left
on the staffs, (and all in silence),
broken. And the staffs all splinter'd and
them, I saw battle-corpses, myriads of
men, And the white skeletons of young

the
thought,
rest, they
the
the musing
suffer'd.

I saw them,
I saw the debris and debris of all
slain soldiers of the war,
But I saw they were not as was
They themselves were fully at
suffer'd not,
The living remain'd and suffer'd,
mother suffer'd,
And the wife and the child and
comrade suffer'd,
And the armies that remain'd

16

night,
my comrades'
bird and
soul,
song, yet
notes,
the

Passing the visions, passing the
Passing, unloosing the hold of
hands,
Passing the song of the hermit
the tallying song of my
Victorious song, death's outlet
varying ever-altering song,
As low and wailing, yet clear the
rising and falling, flooding
night,

warning

night I

spring.

west, fronting

face in

retrievements

the

arous'd

star

of woe,

Sadly sinking and fainting, as

and warning, and yet again
bursting with joy,
Covering the earth and filling the
spread of the heaven,
As that powerful psalm in the

heard from recesses,
Passing, I leave thee lilac with
heart-shaped leaves,
I leave thee there in the dooryard,
blooming, returning with

I cease from my song for thee,
From my gaze on thee in the

the west, communing with
thee,
O comrade lustrous with silver
the night.

Yet each to keep and all,

out of the night,
The song, the wondrous chant of

gray-brown bird,
And the tallying chant, the echo

in my soul,
With the lustrous and drooping

with the countenance full

hand nearing

midst, and

for

all my

for his

with the

the

With the holders holding my

the call of the bird,

Comrades mine and I in the

their memory ever to keep,

the dead I loved so well,

For the sweetest, wisest soul of

days and lands—and this

dear sake,

Lilac and star and bird twined

chant of my soul,

There in the fragrant pines and

cedars dusk and dim.

II. O CAPTAIN! MY CAPTAIN!

fearful trip

rack, the

the

keel, the

O Captain! my Captain! our

is done,

The ship has weather'd every

prize we sought is won,

The port is near, the bells I hear,

people all exulting,

While follow eyes the steady

vessel grim and daring;

But O heart! heart! heart!

O the bleeding drops of

red,
Captain

and

—for

wreaths

crowding,

mass,

head!

the

dead.

lips are

he has

sound, its

Where on the deck my

lies,
Fallen cold and dead.

O Captain! My Captain! rise up

hear the bells;
Rise up—for you the flag is flung

you the bugle trills,
For you bouquets and ribbon'd

—for you the shores a-
For you they call, the swaying

their eager faces turning;
Here Captain! dear father!
This arm beneath your

It is some dream that on

deck,
You've fallen cold and

My Captain does not answer, his

pale and still,
My father does not feel my arm,

no pulse nor will,
The ship is anchor'd safe and

voyage closed and done,

comes
bells!
tread,
Captain lies,

From fearful trip the victor ship
in with object won;
Exult O shores, and ring O
But I with mournful
Walk the deck my
Fallen cold and dead.

III. HUSH'D BE THE CAMPS TODAY

(May 4, 1865)

war-worn
to
conflicts,
time's
across
because

Hush'd be the camps to-day,
And soldiers let us drape our
weapons,
And each with musing soul retire
celebrate,
Our dear commander's death.
No more for him life's stormy
Nor victory, nor defeat—no more
dark events,
Charging like ceaseless clouds
the sky.
But sing poet in our name,
Sing of the love we bore him—
you, dweller in camps,

know it

truly.

earth

As they invault the coffin there,
Sing—as they close the doors of

upon him—one verse,
For the heavy hearts of soldiers.

IV. THIS DUST WAS ONCE THE MAN

under

This dust was once the man,
Gentle, plain, just and resolute,

history

whose cautious hand,
Against the foulest crime in

States.

known in any land or age,
Was saved the Union of these

LYRICS OF THE WAR

BEAT! BEAT! DRUMS!

bugles!

Beat! beat! drums!—blow!

doors

blow!
Through the windows—through

force.

—burst like a ruthless

scatter

Into the solemn church, and

is

—no

now

peace

gathering

you

bugles blow.

bugles!

the rumble

night

must

no

would

would the

the congregation,
Into the school where the scholar

studying;
Leave not the bridegroom quiet

happiness must he have

with his bride,
Nor the peaceful farmer any

ploughing his field or

his grain,
So fierce you whirr and pound

drums—so shrill you

Beat! beat! drums!—blow!

blow!

Over the traffic of cities—over

of wheels in the streets;
Are beds prepared for sleepers at

in the houses? no sleepers

sleep in those beds,
No bargainers' bargains by day—

brokers or speculators—

they continue?
Would the talkers be talking?

court to
judge?
drums—you
bugles!
the weeper
the
nor
the
awaiting the
drums

singer attempt to sing?
Would the lawyer rise in the
state his case before the
Then rattle quicker, heavier
bugles wilder blow.
Beat! beat! drums!—blow!
blow!
Make no parley—stop for no
expostulation,
Mind not the timid—mind not
or prayer,
Mind not the old man beseeching
young man,
Let not the child's voice be heard,
the mother's entreaties,
Make even the trestles to shake
dead where they lie
hearses,
So strong you thump O terrible
—so loud you bugles blow.

COME UP FROM THE FIELDS FATHER

here's
Come up from the fields father,

mother,
son.

green,

with

moderate

hang

vines,

grapes on

the bees

and with

prosper well.

well,

father,

a letter from our Pete,
And come to the front door

here's a letter from thy dear

Lo, 't is autumn,
Lo, where the trees, deeper

yellower and redder,
Cool and sweeten Ohio's villages

leaves fluttering in the
wind,

Where apples ripe in the orchards

and grapes on the trellis'd
(Smell you the smell of the

the vines?
Smell you the buckwheat where

were lately buzzing?)
Above all, lo, the sky so calm, so
transparent after the rain,

wondrous clouds,
Below too, all calm, all vital and
beautiful, and the farm

Down in the fields all prospers

But now from the fields come

the
away.
something
trembling,
hair

his

dear
soul!
flashes with
words

wound in the
taken

better.

Ohio with

come at the daughter's call,
And come to the entry mother, to

front door come right

Fast as she can she hurries,

ominous, her steps

She does not tarry to smooth her

nor adjust her cap.
Open the envelope quickly,
O this is not our son's writing, yet

name is sign'd,
O a strange hand writes for our

son, O stricken mother's

All swims before her eyes,

black, she catches the main

only,
Sentences broken, *gunshot*

breast, cavalry skirmish,

to hospital,
At present low, but will soon be

Ah now the single figure to me,
Amid all teeming and wealthy

all its cities and farms,

in the

through

speechless

says *Pete*

better,

better,

soul,)

door he

drest in

at

often

longing

Sickly white in the face and dull

head, very faint,
By the jamb of a door leans.

*Grieve not so, dear mother, (the
justgrown daughter speaks*

her sobs,
The little sisters huddle around

and dismay'd,)
See, dearest mother, the letter

will soon be better.
Alas poor boy, he will never be

(nor may-be needs to be

that brave and simple

While they stand at home at the

is dead already,
The only son is dead.

But the mother needs to be better,
She with thin form presently

black,
By day her meals untouch'd, then

night fitfully sleeping,

waking,
In the midnight waking, weeping,

unnoticed,

dear

with one deep longing,
O that she might withdraw

silent from life escape and
withdraw,
To follow, to seek, to be with her
dead son.

THE WOUND-DRESSER

1

among new

resuming in

young

me,

beat

relentless

my face

myself,

them,

An old man bending I come

faces,
Years looking backward

answer to children,
Come tell us old man, as from

men and maidens that love
(Arous'd and angry, I'd thought to

the alarum, and urge
war,

But soon my fingers fail'd me,

droop'd and I resign'd
To sit by the wounded and soothe

or silently watch the dead;)
Years hence of these scenes, of

these
chances,
side so
equally
mightiest
wondrous
deepest?
sieges

furious passions, these
Of unsurpass'd heroes, (was one
brave? the other was
brave;)
Now be witness again, paint the
armies of earth,
Of those armies so rapid so
what saw you to tell us?
What stays with you latest and
of curious panics,
Of har'd-fought engagements or
tremendous what deepest
remains?

2

and
the
talking
march
dust,

O maidens and young men I love
that love me,
What you ask of my days those
strangest and sudden your
recalls,
Soldier alert I arrive after a long
cover'd with sweat and
In the nick of time I come,

plunge in the

rush of

like a

fade,

dwell not

soldiers'

the hardships,

projections,

appearance

and

off the

enter the

there,

noise

sponge,

fight, loudly shout in the

successful charge,

Enter the captur'd works—yet lo,

swift-running river they

Pass and are gone they fade—I

on soldiers' perils or

joys,

(Both I remember well—many

few the joys, yet I was
content.)

But in silence, in dreams'

While the world of gain and

and mirth goes on.

So soon what is over forgotten,

waves wash the imprints

sand,

With hinged knees returning I

doors, (while for you up

Whoever you are, follow without

and be of strong heart.)

Bearing the bandages, water and

wounded I go,
after the

reddens the

tent, or

down

I draw

tray, he

and

again,

hand to

are sharp

eyes—

you,

Straight and swift to my
Where they lie on the ground

battle brought in,
Where their priceless blood

grass the ground,
Or to the rows of the hospital

under the roof'd hospital,
To the long rows of cots up and

each side I return,
To each and all one after another

near, not one do I miss,
An attendant follows holding a

carries a refuse pail,
Soon to be fill'd with clotted rags

blood, emptied, and fill'd

I onward go, I stop,
With hinged knees and steady

dress wounds,
I am firm with each, the pangs

yet unavoidable,
One turns to me his appealing

poor boy! I never knew

Yet I think I could not refuse this
moment to die for you, if

that

would save you.

3

open

On, on I go, (open doors of time!

crazed

hospital doors!)

The crush'd head I dress, (poor

hand tear not the bandage
away,)

the

The neck of the cavalry-man with

I

bullet through and through

examine,

glazed

Hard the breathing rattles, quite

already the eye, yet life

struggles

hard,

(Come sweet death! be persuaded

O

beautiful death!

In mercy come quickly.)

amputated

From the stump of the arm, the

hand,

the

I undo the clotted lint, remove

slough, wash off the matter

and

blood,

bends with

Back on his pillow the soldier

falling head,

pale, he

bloody

deep,

the frame

see.

the foot

and

sickening, so

behind aside

pail.

wound

impassive

curv'd neck and side-

His eyes are closed, his face is

dares not look on the

stump,

And has not yet look'd on it.

I dress a wound in the side, deep,

But a day or two more, for see

all wasted and sinking,

And the yellow-blue countenance

I dress the perforated shoulder,

with the bullet-wound,

Cleanse the one with a gnawing

putrid gangrene, so

offensive,

While the attendant stands

me holding the tray and

I am faithful, I do not give out,

The fractur'd thigh, the knee, the

in the abdomen,

These and more I dress with

hand, (yet deep in my

breast a

fire, a burning flame.)

4

projections,

Thus in silence in dreams'

way

Returning, resuming, I thread my

with

through the hospitals,
The hurt and wounded I pacify

night,

soothing hand,
I sit by the restless all the dark

experience

some are so young,
Some suffer so much, I recall the

about this

sweet and sad,
(Many a soldier's loving arms

rested,

neck have cross'd and

these

Many a soldier's kiss dwells on
bearded lips.)

SPIRIT WHOSE WORK IS DONE

(Washington City, 1865)

of

Spirit whose work is done—spirit

dreadful hours!
Ere departing fade from my eyes

your
doubts,
unfaltering
many
spirit,
through the
tireless
flame,
drum,
hollow
reverberates
ranks, return,
yet
bristling over
forests

forests of bayonets;
Spirit of gloomiest fears and
(yet onward ever
pressing,)
Spirit of many a solemn day and
a savage scene—electric
That with muttering voice
war now closed, like a
phantom flitted,
Rousing the land with breath of
while you beat and beat the
Now as the sound of the drum,
and harsh to the last,
round me,
As your ranks, your immortal
return from the battles,
As the muskets of the young men
lean over their shoulders,
As I look on the bayonets
their shoulders,
As those slanted bayonets, whole
of them appearing in the

distance,
returning
swaying to
while
red one
day,
press
bequeath
currents
my
future in

approach and pass on,
homeward,
Moving with steady motion,
and fro to the right and left,
Evenly lightly rising and falling
the steps keep time;
Spirit of hours I knew, all hectic
day, but pale as death next
Touch my mouth ere you depart,
my lips close,
Leave me your pulses of rage—
them to me—fill me with
convulsive,
Let them scorch and blister out of
chants when you are gone,
Let them identify you to the
these songs.

ASHES OF SOLDIERS

murmuring a

Ashes of soldiers South or North,
As I muse retrospective
chant in thought,
The war resumes, again to my

sense

armies.

Virginia

out of

large, or

single

trumpeters,

parading

glistening, and

(ah my

horsemen! what

your shapes,
And again the advance of the

Noiseless as mists and vapors,
From their graves in the trenches
ascending,
From cemeteries all through

and Tennessee,
From every point of the compass

the countless graves,
In wafted clouds, in myriads

squads of twos or threes or

ones they come,
And silently gather round me.

Now sound no note O

Not at the head of my cavalry

on spirited horses,
With sabres drawn and

carbines by their thighs,

brave horsemen!
My handsome tan-faced

life, what joy and pride,
With all the perils were yours.)

Nor you drummers, neither at

reveille

camp,

for a

drummers

marts of

promenade,

close

voiceless,

the dust

soul in

soldiers.

eyes, very

become

at dawn,

Nor the long roll alarming the

nor even the muffled beat

burial,

Nothing from you this time O

bearing my warlike drums.

But aside from these and the

wealth and the crowded

Admitting around me comrades

unseen by the rest and

The slain elate and alive again,

and debris alive,

I chant this chant of my silent

the name of all dead

Faces so pale with wondrous

dear, gather closer yet,

Draw close, but speak not.

Phantoms of countless lost,

Invisible to the rest henceforth

my companions,

Follow me ever—desert me not

while I

the

musical

with

long

love, O

up

love,

of all

cover them

wholesome,

the

live.

Sweet are the blooming cheeks of

living—sweet are the

voices sounding,
But sweet, ah sweet, are the dead

their silent eyes.
Dearest comrades, all is over and

gone,
But love is not over—and what

comrades!
Perfume from battle-fields rising,

from the fœtor arising.

Perfume therefore my chant, O

immortal love,
Give me to bathe the memories

dead soldiers,
Shroud them, embalm them,

all over with tender pride.

Perfume all—make all

Make these ashes to nourish and
blossom,
O love, solve all, fructify all with

last chemistry.
Give me exhaustless, make me a
fountain,
That I exhale love from me
I go like a moist perennial
For the ashes of all dead soldiers
or North.

wherever
dew,
South

PENSIVE ON HER DEAD GAZING

Pensive on her dead gazing I
Mother of All,
Desperate on the torn bodies, on
forms covering the battle-
gazing,
(As the last gun ceased, but the
of the powder-smoke
As she call'd to her earth with
voice while she stalk'd,
Absorb them well O my earth,
I charge you lose not my
lose not an atom,
And you streams absorb them

heard the
the
fields
scent
linger'd,)
mournful
she cried,
sons,
well, taking

that
impalpable,
growth,
woods
blood
to bequeath
North—my
absorb, and
blood,
faithfully
surface
back
give
not

their dear blood,
And you local spots, and you airs
swim above lightly
And all you essences of soil and
and you my rivers' depths,
And you mountain sides, and the
where my dear children's
trickling redde'n'd,
And you trees down in your roots
to all future trees.
My dead absorb or South or
young men's bodies
their precious, precious
Which holding in trust for me
back again give me many
a year hence,
In unseen essence and odor of
and grass, centuries hence,
In blowing airs from the fields
again give me my darlings,
my immortal heroes,
Exhale me them centuries hence,
breathe me their breath, let

soil! O
death,
an atom be lost,
O years and graves! O air and
my dead, an aroma sweet!
Exhale them perennial sweet
years, centuries hence.

CAMPS OF GREEN

old comrades
long
light
night,
the gun
asleep in
and the
surrounding
countersign,
daybreak
Not alone those camps of white,
of the wars,
When as order'd forward, after a
march,
Footsore and weary, soon as the
lessens we halt for the
Some of us so fatigued carrying
and knapsack, dropping
our tracks,
Others pitching the little tents,
fires lit up begin to sparkle,
Outposts of pickets posted
alert through the dark,
And a word provided for
careful for safety,
Till to the call of the drummers at

and sleep
our journey,

green,
filling,
filling,
order'd
halting

their
husbands,
and
sleeping
content and
and

loudly beating the drums,
We rise up refresh'd, the night

pass'd over, and resume
Or proceed to battle.

Lo, the camps of the tents of
Which the days of peace keep

and the days of war keep
With a mystic army, (is it too
forward? is it too only

awhile,
Till night and sleep pass over?)

Now in those camps of green, in

tents dotting the world,
In the parents, children,
wives in them, in the old

young,
Sleeping under the sunlight,
under the moonlight,

silent there at last,
Behold the mighty bivouac-field

waiting camp of all,
Of the corps and generals all, and

the
and generals
of
we
meet.)
camp
camps
outposts,
countersign,

President over the corps
all,
And of each of us O soldiers, and
each and all in the ranks
fought,
(There without hatred we all, all
For presently O soldiers, we too
in our place in the bivouac-
of green,
But we need not provide for
nor word for the
Nor drummer to beat the morning
drum.

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